



What you need to know - Hematopoietic stem cell transplant

This handout tells you what you need to know about a hematopoietic stem cell (bone marrow) transplant to live better and avoid serious problems.



What is it?

- Bone marrow is the soft tissue inside the bones that makes blood cells.
 - All blood cells are made from stem cells found in the bone marrow.
 - New blood cells are always needed to replace old blood cells.
- Stem cells can get damaged or destroyed from different things.
 - Blood conditions, like aplastic anemia, sickle cell disease, or thalassemia
 - Bone marrow cancers, like leukemia, lymphoma, or multiple myeloma
 - Cancer treatments, like chemotherapy or radiation therapy
 - Chemicals that you come in contact with
 - Immune system problems
 - Infections
 - Family history (genetics) of conditions that affect bone marrow
- Some people use other names for a hematopoietic stem cell transplant.
 - Bone marrow transplant
 - Stem cell transplant
 - Nonmyeloablative transplant
 - Mini-transplant
- A hematopoietic stem cell transplant replaces damaged or destroyed bone marrow with healthy bone marrow stem cells.

- It takes 10 to 28 days for the new stem cells to start to work.
- It takes 3 months for the stem cells to work well.



What types of care may I need?

- Goals for care
 - Feel better and stay active
 - Treat and prevent problems
 - Better quality of life
- Medicines
 - Erythropoiesis-stimulating agents (ESAs) help the body make more red blood cells.
 - Immunosuppressives reduce the body's immune system response.
 - Steroids reduce swelling and treat bad flare ups.
- Home healthcare
- Community resources



What follow-up care do I need?

- Surgeon or transplant team visits
- Tests, like blood, urine, or stools
- Cancer screenings, like cervix, breast, colon, prostate, or skin
- Bone density tests for osteoporosis
- Vaccinations that are not made from live viruses
- Annual eye exams
- Dental care



What can I do?

- Managing a hematopoietic stem cell transplant includes following a daily care plan. See the **Daily care for your condition - Organ transplant** handout.
- Make and keep all doctor visits.
- Take your medicine as your doctor told you.
- Stay away from crowds and people who are sick with colds or flu.
- Protect your skin when you go outside. Cover your skin with clothes or wear sunscreen that is SPF30 or higher.
- Protect yourself from injury.
- Keep your weight at a healthy number.
- Take care of your underlying condition, like sickle cell disease.
- Make lifestyle changes, like stop smoking, eat healthy foods, and be active.
- Learn to manage stress. Keep in touch with family and friends. Ask for help if you need it.
- Know when to call for help.
 - Get emergency help right away if you think you are having a heart attack or stroke.
 - Contact your transplant doctor right away if you show signs of rejection.
 - See the **When to get help - Organ transplant** handout.



Where can I learn more?

- Review some Internet resources.
 - Blood & Marrow Transplant Information Network. Go to: www.bmtinfonet.org
 - National Bone Marrow Transplant Link. Go to: www.nbmtlink.org
 - National Cancer Institute. National Institutes of Health. Go to: www.cancer.gov or call 1-800-4-CANCER or 1-800-422-6237

- Smokefree.gov. National Institutes of Health. Go to:
www.smokefree.gov
- Talk to your doctor about what you learn.

This information is general in nature and may not apply to you or your condition. Talk to your doctor or nurse about how to best use this information and how to take care of your medical condition. Be sure to ask your doctor or nurse any questions you might have. This information sheet is not intended to provide or replace professional medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment.

Patient or Caregiver:

Signature: _____ Date: _____

Nurse:

Signature: _____ Date: _____